The 2011 Census data reveals that Uttar Pradesh with a population size of 199 million is the most populous state of India. Uttar Pradesh accounts for about 16% of the country's population. On the other hand, the Himalayan state of Sikkim has a population of just about 0.6 million and Lakshadweep has only 64,429 people.

2. The rate or the pace of population increase is the other important aspect. It is studied in per cent per annum, e.g., a rate of increase of 2% per annum means that in a given year, there was an increase of 2 persons for every 100 persons in the base population.

   This is referred to as the annual growth rate.

   India's population has been steadily increasing from 361 million in 1951 to 1210 million in 2011.

3. There are three main processes of change of population: birth rates, death rates and migration. The natural increase of population is the difference between birth rates and death rates.

   Birth rate is the number of live births per 1000 persons in a year. It is a major component of growth because in India, birth rates have always been higher than death rates.

   Death rate is the number of deaths per 1000 persons in a year. The main cause of the rate of growth of the Indian population has been the rapid decline in death rates.

   The third component of population growth is migration. Migration is the movement of people across regions and territories. Migration can be internal (within the country) or international (between the countries).

4. Water is the most important factor for life. So, people prefer to live in areas where fresh water is easily available. Water is used for drinking, bathing and cooking - and also for cattle, crops, industries and navigation. It is because of this that river valleys are among the most densely populated areas of the world.

   People prefer living on flat plains and gentle slopes. This is because such areas are favourable for the production of crops and to build roads and industries. The mountainous and hilly areas hinder the development of transport network and hence initially do not favour agricultural and industrial development.